Case Study

Phishing Attack Targeting a College Student

Cybercrime Type: Phishing

What is Phishing?

Phishing is a type of cyber-attack in which a criminal impersonates a trustworthy entity — such as a bank, university, or popular website — to trick the victim into revealing sensitive information such as passwords, OTPs, or financial details.

Fictional Scenario

Rohan, a second-year engineering student, received an email that appeared to come from his university's administration. The email subject read: "Urgent: Verify Your Student Portal Access Before It Expires." The email was well-formatted, used the university's logo, and included a link labelled "Click here to verify your account."

Rohan clicked the link and was directed to a website that looked identical to the university's student portal. He entered his username, password, and his registered mobile number. Moments later, he received an OTP on his phone,

which a pop-up on the fake website asked him to enter for "verification."

Within hours, his university account had been accessed by an unknown party. His saved bank details on a linked scholarship portal were compromised, and a fraudulent transaction was attempted.

Who is Typically Targeted?

Students, elderly individuals, and first-time internet users are the most frequent victims because they are less likely to scrutinize URLs, sender addresses, or unexpected urgency in communications.

Consequences

Victims may suffer financial loss, identity theft, emotional distress, and reputational harm. Recovering compromised accounts can take days, and financial recovery is not always guaranteed.